

especially if you're adding on anything like radon testing or a sewer inspection. Yes, this is money that could go down the drain if you're forced to back out of the transaction. No, the seller won't reimburse you.

To which you might ask, "Do I *really* need a home inspection?"

Yes.

One more time, for the people in the back.

Yes!

Don't make us say it again, or so help us, we will turn this car around.

Though it is a \$400–\$600 gamble on a house you don't yet own, it's not as much of a gamble as forfeiting a home inspection and walking into a mysterious house that could fall apart at any minute. You need to know exactly what you're spending hundreds of thousands of dollars on. Big-ticket repairs cost much more than \$600, and you want to know about any issues *before* you're committed to the place for five-plus years.

In case you're still skeptical, let's look at some typical prices of the Big Seven repairs. (Yes, we gave them their own name.)

- Foundation repair—starting at \$10,000, but frequently much higher
- Roof replacement—starting at \$6,000, but can be significantly more
- All-new plumbing system—starting at \$10,000, but can be more. Are you sensing a theme here?
- Electrical rewiring—starting at \$10,000
- Water damage—starting at \$3,000
- Mold removal—starting at \$3,000
- Termite damage—starting at \$5,000

If your soul left your body for a minute, you can rein it back in by knowing that these can all be caught by a home inspection. Phew.

Once you go under contract, you should schedule a home inspection immediately so you don't miss your contractual deadlines. You can either go with your agent's recommendation or find your own inspection company by asking around and doing a little research. Either way, you should make sure you're getting a good home inspector. Make sure they have stellar reviews or at least come highly recommended from your agent, a friend, or a family member. You don't want to go the cheapest route possible—we love saving money too, but this just isn't worth it.